

On Critical Reflection

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Abstract

This paper presents an analysis and clarification of the major role of critical reflection of assumptions (CRA) in adult learning. It examines the differences among types of critical reflection, the role of CRA in the Transformation Theory of adult learning, philosophical foundations of CRA, its development over the lifespan, non-cognitive factors associated with becoming critically reflective, a taxonomy of applications of CRA, and educational implications of CRA.

Figure 1. Stages of Development According to King and Kitchener (1994, p. 208)

1. Stage 1: Single concrete category of knowing. Certain knowledge gained by direct personal observation and needs no justification.
2. Stage 2: Two concrete categories of knowledge. A person can know with certainty through direct observation or indirectly through an authority.
3. Stage 3: Several concrete categories of knowledge are interrelated. Knowledge is assumed to be either absolutely certain or temporarily uncertain. Justification is based on authorities' views or what "feels right."
4. Stage 4: Knowledge is understood as a single abstraction. Knowledge is certain and knowledge claims are assumed to be idiosyncratic to the individual.
5. Stage 5: Two or more abstract concepts of knowledge can be related. Knowledge is seen as contextual and subjective. Beliefs are justified by using the rules of inquiry for the appropriate contexts.
6. Stage 6: Abstract concepts of knowledge can be related. Knowledge is actively constructed by comparing evidence and opinion on different sides of an issue; solutions are evaluated by personally endorsed criteria.
7. Stage 7: Abstract concepts of knowledge are understood as a system. The general principle is that knowledge is the outcome of the process of reasonable inquiry for constructing a well-informed understanding.

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